The Summit Is Not the Climb: AI, Creative Value, and the Displacement Fallacy

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A Reply to Jordan MacKenzie on AI and Valuing Practices

Abstract

Jordan MacKenzie argues that generative artificial intelligence poses two existential threats to human valuing practices: a forward-looking threat in which meaningful creative processes are displaced by merely functional products, and a backward-looking threat in which audiences' indifference to creative provenance reveals a troubling discord in values. This paper challenges the inferences underlying both claims. I argue that technological automation does not necessarily destroy the values associated with established practices, because the historical necessity of an activity must be distinguished from its constitutive significance. Drawing on the coexistence of the Grouse Grind hiking trail and mechanized access to Grouse Mountain, I develop an account of instrumental and constitutive difficulty that explains how automation can preserve intrinsically valued activities while expanding access to their outcomes. I then distinguish productive, receptive, relational, and institutional values, defending a principle of evaluative relevance against the inference from audience preference to indifference toward human creative achievement. Examples involving culinary technology, fan fiction, personal communication, and literary evaluation demonstrate how meaningful agency can survive or expand through technological mediation. Finally, drawing on Foucault and Bourdieu, I distinguish the loss of cultural exclusivity from the loss of intrinsic value. The resulting argument does not deny the possibility of technological harm. Rather, it places a justificatory burden on claims that automation constitutes value destruction and offers a framework for evaluating technological change according to the human goods it preserves, transforms, or enables.

Keywords: artificial intelligence; creative agency; philosophy of technology; process value; aesthetics; automation; technological progress; cultural capital; valuing practices

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1. Introduction: Two Routes to the Summit

On Grouse Mountain, overlooking Vancouver, British Columbia, visitors can reach the summit by two dramatically different methods. They may climb the Grouse Grind, a steep 2.5-kilometre hiking trail demanding substantial physical exertion, or they may ascend by gondola.

Consider two visitors. One wishes to challenge herself physically, improve her fitness, and experience the satisfaction of completing a difficult ascent. The other wishes to admire the scenery, enjoy the mountaintop facilities, and observe the city from above.

Both pursue intelligible and potentially valuable objectives. Yet their reasons for visiting the mountain differ.

For the hiker, the physical ascent constitutes an essential part of the desired experience. Taking the gondola would defeat her purpose. For the sightseer, however, the climb is merely an obstacle between her and the desired destination. Taking the gondola sacrifices nothing essential to her objective.

The existence of the gondola does not diminish the physical accomplishment of completing the Grouse Grind. Nor does the continued availability of the hiking trail establish that visitors who prefer the gondola appreciate the mountain less deeply.

Technology has separated two goods that were once practically inseparable: reaching the summit and earning the summit through physical effort.

This distinction provides a useful starting point for assessing generative artificial intelligence.

In *Fear and Loathing in Silicon Valley: Does AI Threaten Our Valuing Practices?*, Jordan MacKenzie (2026) argues that generative AI poses two existential threats to the ways human beings assign value to activities and their products.

The first threat is forward-looking. By automating activities previously performed by human beings, AI may displace meaningful creative processes and leave us with products appreciated only for their functional or qualitative properties. MacKenzie also worries that cheap automated production may replace excellent work with merely adequate alternatives.

The second threat is backward-looking. AI may reveal that other people do not share the values through which creators understand their own activities. A poet who has devoted decades to mastering literary expression may discover that readers prefer simpler AI-generated poetry. The resulting discrepancy between the creator's commitments and the audience's preferences may produce alienation, disappointment, or a sense of absurdity.

These concerns are not trivial. MacKenzie correctly observes that products can possess significance arising from their histories and that human agency can be expressed through processes of creation, care, and communication. She also recognizes that sophisticated AI users can preserve or extend their agency. Her concern is not that meaningful AI collaboration is impossible, but that people may increasingly surrender valuable activities to automation.

The present paper accepts the importance of process value while challenging the broader significance MacKenzie attributes to its possible displacement.

Its central thesis is that **the replacement of a historically necessary process does not, without further argument, establish the destruction of the values associated with that process**.

Three distinctions support this claim.

First, difficulty that is merely instrumental must be distinguished from difficulty that constitutes part of a valued activity.

Second, the value of producing an object must be distinguished from the value of experiencing it, as well as from the relational and institutional values associated with its production.

Third, the intrinsic significance of creative achievement must be distinguished from the social prestige attached to possessing scarce creative skills.

These distinctions reveal weaknesses in both of MacKenzie's proposed threats. They also support a more positive philosophical account of technological progress: automation can increase human freedom by making previously compulsory forms of labor optional, thereby permitting people to pursue different goods according to their own purposes.

The claim is not that every new technology necessarily improves human flourishing. It is that the loss of an established method must not be mistaken for the loss of the values that method once served.

2. Four Objects of Value: Production, Reception, Relationship, and Institution

MacKenzie distinguishes two forms of valuing. In *qualitative valuing*, an object is appreciated for its properties or functions. In *process valuing*, an object's significance depends upon the history and activities through which it was created or entered someone's life.

This distinction is useful, but it does not settle whose valuing is at issue or which evaluative question is being asked.

Consider a fan-fiction writer who spends several months producing a story.

The writer may value the activity because it permits imaginative exploration, personal expression, and the development of literary skill. A reader may value the story because it is entertaining, moving, or intellectually stimulating. Another writer may value it because it contributes to a community of fellow enthusiasts.

These people need not value the same things, even though their valuations concern the same artifact.

At least four dimensions should therefore be distinguished.

Productive value concerns the significance of the activity through which something is created. It may include enjoyment, achievement, learning, self-expression, and the exercise of agency.

Receptive value concerns the experience of encountering the resulting work. A reader may appreciate a narrative's coherence, humor, emotional force, or literary sophistication without knowing how it was produced.

Relational value concerns the significance an object or activity derives from relationships between persons. A handmade birthday card may be treasured because it expresses affection rather than because of its artistic excellence.

Institutional value concerns the purposes served by practices such as education, artistic competitions, professional certification, or historical testimony. A university assignment, for example, may be intended to assess a student's independent understanding rather than merely the quality of the submitted prose.

These categories are not mutually exclusive. An object may possess several forms of value simultaneously, and they may interact. Nor do they reduce value to a numerical sum.

Their importance lies in preventing illicit inferences from one evaluative domain to another.

An author may derive considerable productive value from writing a technically poor story. A reader may obtain considerable receptive value from a story whose production involved little human labor. A parent may cherish a drawing because of its relational significance. An examiner may reject an otherwise excellent essay because the student failed to perform the intellectual work the assignment was designed to assess.

Each judgment may be justified by different considerations.

This yields the **principle of evaluative relevance**:

Information about an object's production history is relevant to its evaluation when, and to the extent that, such information bears upon the particular kind of value being assessed.

This principle is not a universal defense of aesthetic formalism. Kendall Walton (1970) has argued that artistic categories and contextual knowledge can influence aesthetic perception itself. Historical provenance can therefore sometimes be relevant even to aesthetic judgment.

Nevertheless, evaluating a poem's narrative or linguistic qualities is not identical to evaluating its creator's artistic achievement. Evaluating the sincerity of a personal communication is not identical to evaluating its grammatical elegance.

MacKenzie's two threats become less compelling when these distinctions are preserved.

The forward-looking threat must establish that AI destroys a relevant form of value, rather than merely alters the relationship among forms of value.

The backward-looking threat must establish that divergent evaluative interests constitute a meaningful failure of recognition, rather than an ordinary difference between people engaged in different aspects of a shared practice.

Neither conclusion follows merely from the distinction between qualitative and process valuing.

3. The Displacement Fallacy: Instrumental and Constitutive Difficulty

Return to Grouse Mountain.

The visitor who takes the gondola does not undertake the same activity as the visitor who completes the Grouse Grind. But the difference is not appropriately described as one person obtaining a meaningful experience while the other obtains an impoverished substitute.

Their purposes determine the relevant standards of success.

For the hiker, effort is constitutive of the objective. For the sightseer, it is instrumental.

This suggests a distinction between two kinds of difficulty.

Instrumental difficulty is effort required because of limitations in the available means. It is endured for the sake of another objective.

Constitutive difficulty is effort whose performance forms part of the valued activity itself. Overcoming the difficulty is among the participant's reasons for undertaking the activity.

The distinction is purpose-relative. The same physical task can be instrumentally necessary for one person and intrinsically rewarding for another.

Technological progress often transforms previously necessary effort into optional effort.

Before mechanized transportation, reaching a particular destination might require substantial walking. After mechanization, walking may remain valuable as exercise, recreation, or personal accomplishment, but it is no longer compulsory for everyone seeking the destination.

The historical necessity of walking did not make walking intrinsically valuable to every traveler.

Call the contrary inference the **displacement fallacy**:

From the fact that a technology displaces a traditional activity, it is inferred that the technology destroys the value historically associated with that activity.

The inference requires additional premises.

Let E be an established activity, G an independently identifiable good, and T a technology that permits G to be achieved without performing E.

From the propositions that E previously served G, and that T now permits G without E, it does not follow that the value of G has diminished.

Nor does it follow that E has ceased to possess intrinsic value.

For the inference to succeed, one must show that the replaced activity was constitutive of the particular good under consideration, that meaningful participation in the activity has been impaired, or that the technological alternative introduces losses sufficient to outweigh its benefits.

Consider the history of culinary technology.

A chef cooking over a traditional wood fire must control combustion, fuel, airflow, and the placement of cookware. These tasks may require substantial expertise.

Modern gas stoves permit more direct and precise adjustment of heat. Certain traditional skills consequently become less necessary for ordinary cooking.

But it would be implausible to conclude that the modern chef has thereby ceased to exercise meaningful culinary judgment.

The chef may devote more attention to ingredients, timing, texture, seasoning, and presentation. Some aspects of technical difficulty have disappeared while opportunities for other forms of excellence have increased.

The analogy has limits. Wood-fired cooking can produce distinctive flavors that gas cooking does not automatically reproduce. Traditional techniques may remain indispensable for particular culinary objectives.

But this reinforces rather than undermines the proposed distinction.

Where the traditional technique contributes something constitutive, its preservation may be appropriate. Where it introduces only instrumental difficulty, automation may be an improvement.

Technological progress is not adequately measured by how much labor disappears. It is measured by which goods become easier to realize, which valuable capabilities remain available, and which new possibilities emerge.

The same principle applies to writing.

For one author, constructing elegant sentences is the central pleasure of literary creation. For another, sentence construction is chiefly a means of expressing imagined characters, situations, or philosophical ideas.

AI assistance may diminish the first author's experience while greatly enriching the second author's.

A general claim about the destruction of creativity cannot be inferred from the fact that both are using a technology capable of generating prose.

One must first determine what each author is trying to do.

4. Creative Agency Is Not Identical to Manual Execution

MacKenzie's forward-looking argument also relies upon the relationship between process value and agency.

A creative process can reveal something about the person who undertakes it. The making of an artwork may display imagination, perseverance, judgment, or a distinctive mode of understanding.

But agency does not require performing every operation involved in the production of a result.

Consider an architect designing a building.

The architect may rely on engineering specialists, computer-aided design systems, simulation software, and construction workers. Much of the final structure results from labor the architect does not personally perform.

Nevertheless, important architectural decisions may express the architect's intentions and judgment.

A comparable pattern occurs in contemporary engineering. Electronic design automation performs operations that would be prohibitively time-consuming to execute manually, while the engineer remains responsible for architecture, constraints, trade-offs, verification, and design decisions.

The meaningful intellectual activity has not necessarily disappeared. Its location within the productive process has changed.

The same possibility exists for AI-assisted writing.

An author may determine the central thesis, examine competing arguments, select examples, reject unsatisfactory formulations, test objections, and revise the final structure while delegating much of the sentence-level composition.

The amount of text generated by AI does not directly measure the amount of intellectual agency exercised by the author.

Conversely, typing every sentence manually does not guarantee meaningful intellectual engagement. A writer may mechanically reproduce familiar arguments or follow an imposed formula without substantial independent judgment.

The relevant distinction is therefore not between manual and automated production, but between the exercise and surrender of meaningful agency.

Anthony Cross (2025) offers a related perspective by understanding certain forms of AI art as exploratory practices in which artists create spaces for interaction with generative systems. In such cases, engagement with AI may itself constitute part of the artistic activity.

This does not imply that every prompt is creative or that every AI user meaningfully directs the resulting work.

Someone who generates thousands of texts without examining them may contribute little substantive judgment.

But neither does it follow that extensive automated execution extinguishes agency.

A criterion of creative authorship based entirely on the percentage of work mechanically performed by the human would overlook the distinction between execution and intellectual direction.

This is particularly important when evaluating AI's democratizing potential.

Someone with strong imaginative abilities but limited skill in literary prose may use AI to develop a story that would otherwise have remained unrealized.

Someone with philosophical insight but limited proficiency in academic English may employ AI to articulate arguments that can then be evaluated on their merits.

The technology need not substitute for an established creative life. It may enable participation in a creative activity that was previously inaccessible.

MacKenzie acknowledges that such expansion of agency is possible. Her stronger concern is that the ease of delegation may encourage people to surrender agency gradually, especially before they have acquired the competence needed to exercise critical judgment.

This concern deserves attention. But it is a further empirical and institutional claim, not a conceptual consequence of automation.

5. The Forward-Looking Threat: Advertising, Fan Fiction, and Creative Choice

MacKenzie introduces Marshall, a talented writer who has found himself producing advertorial content. The work affords him opportunities to exercise literary skill even though its principal purpose is commercial. When AI increasingly performs the writing, Marshall experiences a loss of professional satisfaction.

His experience is intelligible.

But the example presents a particular problem: an intrinsically valued activity has been embedded in an institution organized around a largely instrumental objective.

Marshall enjoys some aspects of writing advertorials. His employer commissions advertisements to serve commercial purposes. Most readers do not approach advertisements as opportunities to appreciate literary craftsmanship.

MacKenzie recognizes this divergence. It forms part of her point.

Nevertheless, the example does not establish that the employer's or audience's instrumental valuation is defective.

An employee may find personal meaning in tasks whose broader institutional purpose is comparatively mundane. Automation may reduce the employee's enjoyment without destroying something that customers were obtaining from the activity.

This distinction matters because employment is not always organized around preserving workers' preferred forms of effort.

Marshall's loss may support concerns about the quality of employment, the organization of work, or the economic consequences of automation. It does not establish that the social value of advertising has declined or that consumers ought to regard his creative process as an essential part of the product.

A more revealing example is fan fiction.

Unlike commercial advertising, fan fiction is often produced voluntarily, without compensation, by individuals who enjoy imagining stories and sharing them with fellow enthusiasts.

Karen Hellekson (2009) analyzes fan communities as sites of gift exchange, in which the creation and circulation of stories and other works form part of communal participation.

Suppose a writer devotes her evenings to developing fictional adventures involving characters from a beloved television series.

Her activity may be intrinsically rewarding. She enjoys imagining possibilities, constructing plots, refining dialogue, and sharing her work.

Now suppose AI becomes capable of producing convincing fan fiction.

Three outcomes are possible.

The writer may continue composing every sentence without AI because traditional writing is itself her central pleasure.

Alternatively, she may incorporate AI into her creative practice, using it to explore alternative plots, identify inconsistencies, test dialogue, and develop narrative possibilities.

Finally, she may delegate most of the prose generation while directing the larger imaginative project.

These are different forms of creative participation.

Their respective values depend upon what the participant seeks and what agency she exercises, not merely upon how much text she writes unaided.

Importantly, the availability of machine-generated fiction does not remove the original writer's reason for enjoying traditional composition.

The existence of chess engines superior to human players has not eliminated the reasons people have to play chess. The existence of motor vehicles has not eliminated the intrinsic appeal of recreational cycling.

Likewise, the existence of AI-generated fiction does not establish that traditional literary creation has become meaningless.

The analogy should not be overstated. Creative communities depend upon social infrastructure, attention, and reciprocity. An unlimited supply of automatically generated material could undermine some of these conditions.

But the existence of such possibilities does not demonstrate that AI-assisted creation itself diminishes process value.

It identifies questions about how creative communities are organized.

A platform that rewards mass production rather than meaningful engagement may reduce opportunities for valuable interaction. A community that distinguishes AI-assisted fiction, traditional writing, and interactive storytelling may sustain several forms of participation.

Neither outcome follows simply from the capabilities of generative AI.

The forward-looking threat thus requires an additional account of why harmful forms of adaptation should be expected to dominate beneficial ones.

Without such an account, the argument demonstrates that automation can create losses under certain conditions. It does not establish a general tendency toward the disappearance of valuable creative practices.

6. Personal Expression: Sincerity Rather Than Production Method

One objection to the preceding argument concerns interpersonal relationships.

Perhaps process value matters not merely because creators enjoy their activities, but because their actions express care for others.

MacKenzie's examples of love letters, personal gifts, and children's artwork bring out this concern.

Consider a daughter who wishes to send her father a poem.

She might compose the poem herself, copy it from a book, or generate it with AI.

Suppose she has given the matter no thought. She selects words at random, fails to consider whether they express anything she feels, and presents the result as a deeply personal gesture.

The act may carry little relational value, regardless of how the words were obtained.

Conversely, suppose she carefully selects an existing poem because it articulates precisely what she wishes to communicate.

Although she did not compose the words, her selection may itself express care.

The same possibility applies to AI-assisted composition.

A daughter who develops a poem through sustained interaction with AI, supplies personal memories, rejects insincere expressions, and deliberately adopts the final result may communicate genuine affection.

The relevant distinction is between thoughtful and thoughtless expression, not necessarily between human-produced and machine-generated language.

Nor is this problem unique to AI.

People have long copied love poems, purchased greeting cards, employed ghostwriters, and used conventional expressions of affection.

Such practices may be sincere or insincere depending upon their circumstances.

AI may reduce the effort required to produce convincing messages, but the possibility of communicating without meaningful personal engagement predates generative technology.

MacKenzie's example of a cherished clock given by her aunt is instructive.

The aunt did not manufacture the clock. Its significance arose from her attachment to it and her willingness to give it away.

The relevant expression of agency was an act of intentional giving rather than the technical production of an object.

This demonstrates that relational value may arise from selection, adoption, and purposeful action independently of original manufacture.

The same possibility should remain open in AI-mediated communication.

Of course, the method of production can matter when the recipient reasonably understands a communication to represent a particular expenditure of personal effort.

A person who falsely claims to have spent days writing a poem may deceive its recipient.

But the wrong concerns misrepresentation, not merely the use of a particular technological instrument.

The appropriate evaluative question is whether the communication genuinely expresses the sender's intentions and satisfies the relevant relational expectations.

AI authorship alone cannot answer that question.

7. The Backward-Looking Threat: Preference Is Not Indifference

MacKenzie's backward-looking argument is especially interesting because it concerns not what AI might destroy, but what it may reveal.

A creator may discover that an audience never cared about the activities the creator considered meaningful.

A poet who prizes complexity and ambiguity may learn that ordinary readers prefer accessible AI-generated poetry.

MacKenzie argues that such discoveries can expose valuing discord and produce feelings of alienation or absurdity.

But the inference from audience preference to the absence of shared process values is insufficiently supported.

Consider a reader who prefers an AI-generated poem to a human-written poem.

The reader may still admire the technical and intellectual achievement represented by the human poem.

There is no contradiction.

Let M denote an AI-generated poem, H a human-authored poem, and A an audience member.

The audience might judge that:

$V_{reading}(A, M) > V_{reading}(A, H)$.

Yet the same audience member may also assign positive value to the human creative achievement represented by H:

$V_{achievement}(A, H) > 0$.

These propositions are compatible.

Consequently, an audience's preference for AI-produced poetry does not establish that the audience is indifferent toward human creative processes.

This is not merely a theoretical possibility. It exposes a limitation in how evidence about aesthetic preferences may be interpreted.

Porter and Machery (2024) found that nonexpert readers often rated selected AI-generated poems more favorably than poems by established human poets.

The researchers also found that participants gave lower ratings to poems when told they were AI-generated, regardless of their actual origin.

These results indicate that aesthetic responses to poetic texts and beliefs about authorship can influence judgment in distinguishable ways.

They do not establish that ordinary readers are indifferent to human creative achievement.

Indeed, participants' sensitivity to authorship information complicates that interpretation.

Nor does the preference for accessible poetry establish that readers possess shallow aesthetic values.

Some readers may value interpretive complexity, ambiguity, and allusion. Others may value clarity, emotional immediacy, and communicative force.

The latter preferences are not obviously inferior.

An argument for the superiority of a particular poetic ideal must identify the merits supporting that judgment. It cannot derive superiority simply from the difficulty of producing or interpreting the relevant work.

This is where controlled evaluation becomes philosophically useful.

Imagine a literary competition in which readers evaluate three anonymous stories: one written without AI, one created through extensive human–AI collaboration, and one generated with minimal human intervention.

Participants assess specified literary qualities without knowing the stories' production histories. If the evaluation is genuinely double-blind, even those administering the assessment lack identifying information until judgments have been collected.

Suppose the AI-generated story receives the highest ratings.

The result does not establish that its production involved the greatest human achievement.

But neither does the greater effort required to produce another story establish its superiority along the qualities being evaluated.

These are separate questions.

A double-blind evaluation is not the uniquely correct way to judge every artwork. Provenance and context may appropriately influence judgments involving artistic history, originality, or expressive intention.

Its philosophical significance is more modest and more important: it prevents irrelevant information about production from determining an assessment whose purpose is to measure qualities of the experienced work.

The broader principle is that an audience may legitimately value what a work offers without adopting the creator's reasons for making it.

The absence of identical evaluative commitments does not establish that either party has misunderstood the activity.

8. Recognition Without Ratification: The Poet and the Cup Stacker

MacKenzie's backward-looking argument may be defended by appealing to the importance of social recognition.

People do not pursue valued activities solely for private satisfaction. They often seek relationships and communities in which those activities are appreciated.

A poet whose work loses social recognition may experience a genuine injury to identity and belonging.

This concern deserves a careful response.

The distinction needed is between **recognition** and **ratification**.

Recognition involves acknowledging another person's commitments, achievements, and legitimate standing as a participant in a practice.

Ratification involves adopting that person's substantive judgment about the comparative importance or excellence of the activity.

The former may sometimes be morally required. The latter generally is not.

One may respect a friend's dedication to classical music without preferring classical music to jazz. One may admire a chess player's skill without regarding chess as a particularly important personal pursuit.

Likewise, a reader may recognize the significance of a poet's creative achievement without preferring the poet's work to an AI-generated alternative.

To illustrate the difference, consider two individuals who devote twenty years to mastering their respective activities.

One is a poet. The other is a competitive cup stacker.

The poet masters meter, imagery, and literary expression. The cup stacker masters extraordinary speed, coordination, and technical precision.

Both may derive substantial satisfaction from their activities. Both may participate in communities that recognize their achievements.

Yet the social prestige associated with poetry may differ considerably from that associated with competitive cup stacking.

Why should the poet's disappointment at declining public recognition constitute a threat to human valuing when the cup stacker's limited cultural prestige does not?

One possible answer is that poetry has greater cultural significance.

Perhaps it does. Poetry may possess distinctive expressive, cognitive, historical, and interpersonal value.

But that conclusion requires an independent argument.

The mere fact that poetry demands years of training cannot establish its superiority. The cup stacker's activity also demands considerable skill.

Nor does the fact that poetry historically enjoyed greater prestige establish that society must preserve its former position.

The intrinsic value of pursuing an activity does not depend upon the continuation of its established social ranking.

A poet may sincerely love writing and also desire recognition. There is no contradiction between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation.

Nevertheless, a desire for recognition does not create an unrestricted entitlement to public admiration, commercial success, or continued cultural prestige.

MacKenzie's account identifies the psychological vulnerability involved in discovering that others do not share one's commitments.

But psychological disappointment does not by itself establish that an audience has failed to recognize what it ought to recognize.

The relevant question is whether the audience has violated a reasonable expectation of respect, care, or participation.

An artist's hope that others will appreciate difficult poetry does not automatically create such an expectation.

The distinction becomes especially important when technological development expands access to previously scarce creative capabilities.

A decline in the prestige associated with specialized production skills may be experienced as a loss by their possessors.

Yet the broader availability of those capabilities may increase the opportunities available to others.

The loss of social distinction must not be mistaken for the loss of intrinsic creative value.

9. Foucault, Bourdieu, and the Democratization of Creative Authority

The relationship between creative expertise and prestige introduces a further philosophical concern.

Michel Foucault's *What Is an Author?* (1969; English translation 1977) examines the historically variable ways in which discourse is organized through the attribution of authorship.

The author's institutional role is not simply a transparent reflection of the individual who produced a text. Authorship also functions through conventions determining how texts are classified, interpreted, attributed, and authorized.

This perspective is relevant to AI-assisted creativity.

Historically, cultural authority has been associated with particular competencies: literacy, linguistic refinement, mastery of artistic technique, and familiarity with established intellectual traditions.

Universities, publishers, journals, and other institutions help define which competencies count as evidence of legitimate authorship or expertise.

Generative AI can weaken the relationship between possessing these established competencies and producing certain kinds of culturally recognized work.

Someone with a compelling philosophical argument but limited proficiency in academic English may now formulate a polished essay through AI assistance.

Someone without advanced illustration skills may develop sophisticated visual narratives.

Such cases raise a question about the relationship between technical proficiency and intellectual or artistic authority.

When a work can be evaluated directly for logical coherence, originality, insight, or communicative effectiveness, why should conventional production methods retain independent authority unless they contribute to the value being assessed?

A Foucauldian analysis does not establish that inherited standards are illegitimate.

It asks which standards protect valuable forms of achievement and which serve primarily to regulate entry into established cultural practices.

Pierre Bourdieu's *Distinction* (1979; English translation 1984) provides a complementary framework.

Bourdieu argues that cultural tastes and competencies are embedded in social structures. Particular forms of artistic appreciation can function as markers of education, class, and cultural capital.

This does not imply that all claims of artistic superiority are reducible to social power.

Rather, it complicates the assumption that established judgments of taste are independent of the institutions and social positions through which they are cultivated.

Consider again the Grouse Grind.

Before mechanized access, reaching a remote summit might have been a privilege available only to those possessing sufficient physical ability and resources.

The gondola reduces the exclusivity of the destination.

Those who previously enjoyed prestige merely from having reached the summit may lose some of that distinction.

But hikers who value the physical accomplishment of climbing have lost none of the effort required to complete the ascent.

The change affects the distribution of access and prestige, not necessarily the intrinsic value of the original activity.

A similar process may occur when AI democratizes the production of polished prose, illustrations, or other creative works.

Some traditional competencies become less scarce. Consequently, the cultural distinction derived from possessing them may decline.

Yet this does not establish that the capacities themselves have lost intrinsic value.

A traditionally trained writer may continue to value literary craftsmanship. An AI-assisted writer may exercise a different combination of imaginative, critical, and compositional capacities.

The existence of the latter does not invalidate the former.

A theory of threatened valuing practices must therefore distinguish three possible losses: the disappearance of valuable opportunities, the diminution of artistic or intellectual quality, and the erosion of positional prestige.

Only the first two directly support a claim that human creative opportunities or achievements have deteriorated. The third may instead indicate a redistribution of cultural authority.

This is a structural criticism of an argument, not an allegation about the motivations of its author.

Nothing in the analysis establishes that MacKenzie personally wishes to preserve elite exclusivity.

The challenge is conceptual: an account of creative value must not treat the established prestige of a difficult practice as sufficient evidence of that practice's superiority over newly accessible alternatives.

The democratization of a capability is not, without further argument, the destruction of its value.

10. The Strongest Objection: Technology May Change What People Are Capable of Valuing

The preceding arguments might be criticized for assuming that valuable traditional activities will remain available whenever people wish to pursue them.

MacKenzie's strongest forward-looking objection challenges precisely that assumption.

A technological environment does not merely provide people with tools. It can shape their competencies, expectations, habits, and motivations.

Suppose children grow up relying on AI to compose stories and arguments. They may never develop the skills through which earlier generations discovered the satisfaction of independent composition.

Even if traditional writing remains technically possible, people may lack the capacity or inclination to pursue it.

Similarly, creative communities may depend upon economic support, reciprocal attention, and institutions that can be undermined by large-scale automation.

The continued physical possibility of writing a poem does not guarantee the survival of a flourishing poetic culture.

This objection is substantial.

It shows that technological freedom cannot be evaluated solely by counting the options formally available to individuals.

An option has practical significance only when the relevant capabilities and conditions of participation are sufficiently accessible.

Nevertheless, this does not vindicate MacKenzie's broader diagnosis without further argument.

First, the objection must identify which capacities are valuable and why particular forms of unaided practice are necessary to develop them.

The ability to reason critically, for example, is not identical to the ability to produce polished prose without technological assistance.

These skills can overlap, but their relationship is not self-evident.

AI might diminish reasoning ability when users accept answers uncritically. Yet it might improve reasoning when users employ it to examine objections, compare arguments, and expose inconsistencies.

The relevant empirical question concerns how the technology is used and what competencies the resulting activities cultivate.

Second, the objection must consider opportunities gained as well as lost.

A person previously excluded from literary creation by language barriers may develop substantial creative interests through AI assistance.

Such a person has not lost a valued traditional practice. She has gained access to a form of participation that was previously difficult or impossible.

A complete evaluation must consider these new forms of agency rather than treating the experiences of established practitioners as the exclusive baseline.

Third, institutional conditions matter.

If education rewards the uncritical submission of AI-generated material, students may have incentives to avoid developing understanding.

But this is partly a problem of assessment design.

An educational institution can require demonstrations of reasoning, oral defense, iterative revision, or independent performance where those are the competencies being assessed.

Likewise, creative communities can distinguish among traditional writing, AI-assisted collaboration, and automated content production where such distinctions matter to their purposes.

These measures are not guaranteed to succeed. Their significance is that the harmful effects of a technology cannot be inferred independently of the practices through which it is adopted.

The relevant philosophical problem is therefore comparative.

Which feasible arrangement best preserves valuable human capabilities while expanding opportunities for participation?

The answer cannot be determined by assuming that established production methods must remain compulsory.

Nor can it be determined by assuming that technological development inevitably produces better outcomes.

It requires identifying the goods at stake and examining how different arrangements affect them.

11. Technological Corrigibility and the Burden of Proof

The distinction between technological capability and institutional implementation suggests a broader response to MacKenzie's argument.

Technological change frequently produces undesirable consequences alongside new benefits.

The philosophical response should not automatically be to restore the earlier technical limitations.

Instead, one should identify the mechanisms producing the undesirable consequences and examine whether they can be corrected while retaining the valuable capabilities introduced by the technology.

Call this the principle of *technological corrigibility*.

Technological corrigibility does not mean that every technological problem can necessarily be solved by another invention.

Some difficulties involve scarce resources, conflicting preferences, incompatible objectives, or genuine moral disagreements.

No recommendation algorithm can guarantee that every poet receives an appreciative audience. Nor can technology establish a general obligation to admire particular artistic practices.

Nevertheless, many difficulties associated with technological change are open to further technical and institutional adaptation.

When software creates unreliable outputs, verification methods can be improved.

When automated systems create undesirable incentives, those incentives can sometimes be redesigned.

When a technological tool permits users to bypass valuable learning processes, educational institutions can reconsider how understanding is cultivated and assessed.

The possibility of such responses matters when deciding whether a technological development represents an unavoidable threat to human values.

The history of innovation provides ample reason to distinguish problems associated with a particular implementation from defects inherent in the new capability.

This does not justify technological complacency.

It establishes that critics must examine feasible improvements rather than compare an idealized past with an uncorrected technological future.

A more general principle follows:

When a technology replaces an established method, the critic who claims that this replacement destroys value must identify the value allegedly lost, establish its dependence upon the displaced method, and provide reasons to believe the loss is significant and cannot be adequately avoided through feasible alternatives or adaptations.

This is not an asymmetric exemption for technological advocates.

Those who claim that AI will improve creative life also bear a burden of justification for their positive predictions.

But a distinction must be maintained between claims of possibility, probability, and general consequence.

That AI *can* undermine a valuable activity is a relatively modest proposition.

That AI is *likely* to undermine important activities across realistic conditions requires additional evidence.

That AI constitutes a *general existential threat* to human valuing practices is stronger still.

The first proposition does not establish the third.

MacKenzie's argument persuasively identifies some of the goods that may be at risk. It is less successful in establishing that generative AI, as opposed to particular incentives and patterns of use, creates a sufficiently general danger to those goods.

This is especially important because technological change may increase the total range of valuable human activities even while diminishing the importance of some established skills.

Printing altered the role of scribal copying. Modern transportation changed the necessity of walking long distances. Computers transformed calculation, drafting, editing, and engineering design.

These transformations involved real changes in the distribution of skills, opportunities, and social recognition.

But the disappearance of a former technological necessity was not, by itself, a sufficient reason to condemn the development.

Likewise, generative AI should not inherit a presumption of value destruction merely because it alters historically familiar relations between effort and achievement.

The appropriate standard is the comparative effect upon human agency, understanding, creativity, relationships, and access.

12. Conclusion: The Summit Is Not the Climb

MacKenzie's account of AI and valuing practices captures important truths about human life.

We care about the processes through which things are created. We value activities that express our agency. We seek recognition from others, and we can experience genuine disappointment when our commitments are not shared.

These observations, however, do not establish that generative AI poses a general existential threat to human valuing.

The forward-looking argument risks moving too quickly from the displacement of traditional labor to the disappearance of valuable activity.

The distinction between instrumental and constitutive difficulty reveals why this inference is unwarranted. Automation may eliminate effort that was historically unavoidable while preserving or expanding opportunities to undertake the same effort voluntarily.

The backward-looking argument risks interpreting differences between the evaluative interests of creators and audiences as evidence of indifference or deficient recognition.

Yet the value of making something and the value of experiencing it are distinct. A reader may prefer an AI-generated poem while still recognizing the significance of human poetic achievement.

Nor does an individual's dedication to a difficult activity create an unrestricted entitlement to public admiration.

Foucault and Bourdieu further illuminate the need to distinguish intrinsic creative value from the cultural authority and prestige associated with scarce competencies.

The democratization of a capability may challenge established hierarchies without diminishing the value of the activities through which those hierarchies developed.

None of this implies that technological progress is incapable of producing losses.

Creative skills may deteriorate under poorly designed educational arrangements. Communities may be weakened by adverse incentives. Personal relationships may be damaged by insincere or deceptive communication.

But these concerns demand analysis of particular mechanisms, practices, and institutions.

They do not establish that AI-generated work is intrinsically devoid of meaningful human agency or that technological assistance necessarily impoverishes creativity.

Return, finally, to Grouse Mountain.

The hiker who completes the Grouse Grind has achieved something real. The availability of a gondola does not lessen the physical effort, perseverance, or satisfaction involved in the climb.

The visitor who takes the gondola also obtains something valuable. The view does not become less beautiful because its enjoyment required less physical exertion.

Both activities can coexist because they serve different human purposes.

Similarly, the writer who loves crafting sentences may continue writing unaided. The storyteller who loves developing ideas may use AI to realize them. The reader may assess the finished work according to the experience it provides. Each participant may value a different aspect of the activity without diminishing the others.

Technological progress is at its best when it enables such differentiation.

It makes formerly necessary obstacles optional, expands access to valuable experiences, and allows people to decide which forms of effort are worth undertaking for their own sake.

The preservation of human creativity does not require the preservation of every difficulty that once constrained it.

The summit is not the climb.

Making the summit accessible to more people does not make climbing worthless.

And making creative expression accessible to more people does not, by itself, diminish the value of human creativity.

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